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Pete Barbutti

Pete Barbutti has created a unique niche for himself as an accomplished multi-instrumentalist, comedian, and engaging personality. His career includes appearances in major Las Vegas clubs and on all the iconic talk shows.

Pete was interviewed via Zoom on December 9, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: All right. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm in Clinton, New York.

PB: There's something on the screen here.

MR: Something on the screen?

PB: Yeah. It just says the meeting is being recorded by the host.

MR: Right. Yeah, that's fine. It just means that we're good. Good cool, I'll start again.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Pete Barbutti with me today. I really appreciate you taking your time out. And I have a lot of questions and I'll try to start with a softball and that is, you're still gigging, is that correct? You mentioned New Year's Eve, yeah.

PB: I am. I work a local club here once in a while and of course I do all of the Las Vegas Jazz Society things, sort of a master of ceremonies.

MR: Yeah. When you do New Year's Eve do you still get to play till midnight?

PB: This year is strange. Usually that's what you do and I don't like that. I mean everybody hates working New Year's Eve you know, it's the same thing. One year at the Sahara Hotel there was, in the lounge, I was doing it as a joke, I said, "Okay we have a new thing here, what we do at midnight is you people come up here and finish the show and we go out there and finish your drinks." And everybody laughed. And then sure enough, twelve o'clock came and the entire audience started to crawl across the bar to get on the stage. They took it literally.

MR: Don't you just love the noisemakers?

PB: Yeah, right. One of the things burned in my mind is, again it was New Year's Eve at the Sahara and David Brenner, rest his soul he was a good guy, David was on stage in the showroom. And so I went back and stood in the wings and looked and David was doing his act and there were a thousand people in the room, that's absolute capacity. And not one of them was watching the stage or listening to anything he was saying. They were all yelling and screaming. And he looked over at me and he saw me, and the two of us just broke up, it was like futile. It was simply no use.

MR: Yeah, sometimes reality is funnier than intended comedy I guess.

PB: I think so too, yeah. I have to tell you, you just said something that I flashed on. Excuse me for interrupting.

MR: Go ahead.

PB: I had a local agent call me a couple of years ago and he said I have an Indian casino down in Scottsdale, Arizona. He said, "They're really nice people and it's an easy show during the week like on a Tuesday or Wednesday or Thursday you do one show and then a couple on weekends. And they do nice crowds. And the guy who runs the place is a fan of yours so he'll pick up all your expenses and there's a brand new condo they give you to stay in, fully equipped. It was a nice thing. It was not too far to drive. So I went down there and I got there and the band was a rock band, like a trio, and they had no idea what I was doing you know. So rather than go through a whole thing and lose my cool or anything I just said, "Look when I go like this or I say this, just play a B flat chord or something — you know, no use fighting it. And so that's good enough, because most of it I did mostly, you know instead of the music I did mostly just straight stand-up. And I found the opening act was an Elvis impersonator, and then there was a girl who did an impersonation of Stevie Nicks, who is a rock & roll singer, and then the next act was a group of four or five guys who did the Temptations, you know, sang all their songs and so forth. And then I went on and just before I let them close the show and then they said, "On the weekends we go out and stand in the casino behind the theater row and the people come by and we thank them for coming in and shake their hand." I said fine. So I went out there and the people were coming by and they were saying to me, "You look just like him." There was no response. There was no appropriate response. What am I going to say, "I am him?" or "Thank you?"

MR: "Why thank you, my impersonations must have been a success."

PB: Yeah. It was very strange. I've never had that happen before or since.

MR: Yeah. It's funny you say that about, you know warm up acts. I played in a rock & roll band for years and one time we showed up in Rochester and we were warming up for a turtle race. "Yeah, my career is really on the upswing here."

PB: That's a spin-off about the old joke about the band who works New Year's Eve and the club owner says "You guys are great, I'd like to have you again for New Year's Eve." And the drummer says, "Oh that's great, can I leave my drums here?"

MR: The question that's been rattling around in my head since I knew we were going to meet, when you were getting ready to graduate from high school is it true that you turned down a music scholarship to Penn State?

PB: Yeah. You know I had the chance to go on the road with a band and that to me was infinitely more exciting. Although I loved classical music, you know I was doing a lot, in fact I was playing with the Philharmonic when I was in high school. A percussionist. And

I was playing with the University of Scranton band and I was playing with what they call the Demolay Band and the Shriner band, and then there was another fine orchestra in town called the Cetta Parish band. And I was doing all of those playing percussion.

MR: Did your parents question your choice to not take that scholarship?

PB: No. No. They were supportive of just about anything I wanted to do. I'm not sure it was the right or wrong choice or whatever, you know it doesn't matter as you look back. But I think sometimes maybe it would have been fun to do that but then again I don't know.

MR: What were you like as a junior high student?

PB: Well first of all let me back up a little, I was incredibly shy as a kid. I mean unbelievably. In fact I just remembered the other day when I needed new shoes I was too shy to even go in the shoe store so my sister, who was like eight years older, she would go in the store and bring the shoes out and try them on me in the car. I mean it was almost like an emotional thing. And I was like that until at age nine or ten they said, "You should take accordion lessons." 'Cause everybody in the neighborhood, all the Italian kids played the accordion, all the Jewish kids played violin, and the girls played piano. Piano was considered feminine. Strangely enough I went to see Arturo Sandoval at his invitation which I was thrilled with because I love him. And he said the same thing in the Cuban culture, the piano is considered feminine, so he used to practice the piano but he had to hide it because people would think he was gay if he played the piano you know. But everybody, my cousin and I, my cousin Ray and I got, we both took accordion lessons and we both had a beginner-style accordion and I studied with Professor Sebastianelli and of course the first four or five months was nothing but solfeggio, you know just singing the notes without playing the accordion. Then when I'd get home I'd play the accordion. And that sort of gave me a reason to be different on stage or to go out in public, it sort of gave me some confidence. And then when I got into high school, we had a hot shot baseball team, we won the city championship and so I was more into sports and running track. And I had to take an elective subject so I said well I'll take band. And the professor, the teacher there was a guy named Gene Morris. He was in a Navy band, played trombone, he was a very hip guy, and he was a great arranger and everything. I mean he was — and very today. And there was a piano player who was in the band too, his name was Charlie Coleman. And Charlie was way above his pay grade. Charlie was — I mean we used to go down to the record store and play a Stan Kenton record, you know. In the old days you went in the booth and while you were there you could play the record. He'd play it four or five times and then he'd go home and he could score it for the band. I mean in high school. So Charlie was a year older than me, graduated a year before I did. And I wasn't sure what I was going to do but I loved music so very much and having the accordion was — it changed everything.

MR: There's something about having an instrument or something between you and the audience or the people that are watching.

PB: Yeah well you know the first group I was with was called Teddy Voltz and the Overtones. It was a real bebop group. It was accordion, bass and guitar. And I remember you know we'd start playing tunes, we were doing Lennie Tristano and Miles and all those tunes. And if the audience, like if they started dancing or something we'd change the tempo. It was like an insult that they were enjoying it. You know we were like real artists. And so it got to the point where we had fewer and fewer gigs. And so they'd push me up front to announce the songs, because I was the least inhibited of the group. And I got bored with saying, "Here's a song written by, you know, Cole Porter," and so I'd start doing, "Here's a song written by Cole Porter and Clyde Beatty and a small fishing boat with Marie Dressler." I'd go through this big long introduction and the audience would turn around and they'd applaud for the introduction then ignore the song. So I realized then that, you know, I got more and more confidence. Then when I started to work with a trio, first we went on the road and then we worked with some old guy from Toronto who really tried to corrupt us in terms of music and comedy and everything. And then when that broke up then I put together my dream group, you know, with the guitar player that I went to high school with, a saxophone player who was I think a year and a half older, and a drummer that I had known since he was a little kid. And that group was called the Millionaires. And we went on the road. We did really, really well. We were very successful. That was in the 50s. And we worked Jackson, Mississippi in the 50s which I can tell you was an experiment in lifestyles you know because when I went to school there were a substantial amount of black kids in the school even in the 50s in high school. And we got to Mississippi and boy we ran into some real problems.

MR: Like can you be specific?

PB: Yeah we had — first of all we had to play "Dixie" to open every show, and then there were no black people allowed in there. There were no black people who were allowed in the same stores we went in, nobody at the lunch counters, nobody in the restaurants. They had their own little thing. And when we'd play certain kind of music they'd come by and they'd say, "Stop playing that — you know the N word — music." And we had one incident where there was a young black kid worked in the restaurant, he swept up and carried things, like a bus boy sort of. His name was Robert. And he liked us and we hung out with him and it was unusual for him to meet northern people I mean there just weren't any around there, this was in Jackson, Mississippi. And so the sax player with the car had a '49 Cadillac convertible, it was canary yellow, it was a block and a half long and weighed about six tons. It was the most magnificent automobile with the fins, I mean it was something to see. And on our day off, which was Sunday, Jimmy — Robert used

to wash the car for Jimmy every day. And there was a sort of a symbolic thing with him that someday he might own a car like that. He'd wash it, he'd sit in it and you know. He was an adult. I mean he was young but he was an adult. And so on our day off Jimmy threw Robert the keys and said, "Robert, take your girlfriend for a ride just don't drink when you're driving." You know, "Take your girlfriend." Because we were going to hang out with some girl singers that were new down there, we had an apartment back there, we were going to party a little bit and play some cards and stuff. And about two o'clock in the morning he was banging on the door and we opened the door and it was two very redneck cops and they says, "We caught the Nigger (pardon the expression but that's the phrase they used) who stole your car." And we had no idea about the culture and I was the most articulate of the group probably so I started arguing with him, not knowing that in that day and age they'd just shoot you and that's the end of it you know. And I started arguing, I said, "No we loaned him the car and I'll go down right now to the police station and sign an affidavit saying that we loaned him the car." And then they started to walk out and then they came back and banged on the door again and they said, "We have to arrest you. We're charging you. And the charge was loaning a Nigger a car.

MR: Oh Lord.

PB: You know culturally you can't understand it. It was very confusing. And yet the people we worked for were the loveliest family, the Taylor family, they were just very good to us, they were great people. But the whole thing was real tough for us.

MR: Can I ask you, this is pretty specific, but if you were playing a gig down there and you played "Tutti Frutti" if you announced it as Pat Boone instead of Little Richard, would that have been okay?

PB: I think so. Yeah. The difference didn't seem so physical as it was metaphysical. Very strange. I still have a bad taste in my mouth from it. We also went to see — we were working a club in Shreveport, Louisiana and it was called the Great American City the sign said as we pulled in. And I saw in the newspaper Billy Eckstine and his band were going to appear there. And those were the old days when Billy wasn't a star yet, because he was just starting to make some noise in the business, had a couple of hit records and of course on his band Charlie Parker was on saxophone and Lester Young was on saxophone and his piano player was Sarah Vaughan. I mean you know, and in those days everybody kept track of that in that generation. You know we knew all the sidemen in every band and everything. And so I said to one of the black kids, porters in the club, I said, "Can you get us some tickets for this?" He said "Yeah, that's in our part of town." I said, "That's okay, we want to go see Billy Eckstine's band." So I said — tickets were like five dollars or four dollars. So I said, "Get one for each of us in the band and here's another eight dollars you get two for you and your girlfriend" or whatever. So we went

there, we kept our uniforms on, because we didn't know what the situation was, and we wore a saxophone strap. So we walked in there and it was an unbelievable band and like a half hour later I get this poke in my back and turned around and it was a redneck white cop, said, "What are you doing in here?" And they threw us out. And I stopped the police car, I mean, we had no idea you know how dangerous it was because we were kids, we were still in our teens. And I explained what happened. And the cops said, "Well why did you go in there?" I said, "We saw Billy Eckstine." He said, "What's Billy Eckstine doing in that club?" "Well it's a black club, and Billy Eckstine's black." He said, "Why did you want to see him?" It was beyond — there was no logic to it.

MR: I'm surprised that you're still here to talk about it.

PB: Yeah me too, in retrospect, you know we were kids and we were raised in the north in Pennsylvania in Scranton, so we had no idea that this existed.

MR: When you discovered, at some point, I'm not sure if it would have been the accordion or the trumpet, but that you could play music that wasn't specifically written on a piece of paper. Did that feeling eventually help your comedy routines?

PB: Oh yeah. Yeah. Because comedy — I just talked to somebody that was a great entertainer, he's living back in the New England states now and we talked about it a little bit. He said, "You came into my dressing room, we're working together, and you gave me this big lecture about jazz and comedy being the same thing. He says, "I still remember." It was a long time ago. But yeah, I was a crusader for that because it's the same thing. When you're playing jazz you're still — it's obligatory that you stick to the same chord structure, and you can't add a beat whenever you want to, you're — you know the specific number of beats. And what you do is within this framework you take the liberties and you change the melody but you're still obligated to stay within the same number of bars and whatever it is, the same chord structure. Comedy is the same thing. There has to be a believability you know, the infamous pig joke that I did on the Tonight Show. You start off with something that's really real and it's true and you went to this guy's farm and he had the pig and you know, and you go through this whole thing, but there has to be a reality to it. You can't say there was this elephant flying over, you know, I mean right away people know there's nothing to that. So you have a reality to it and then you ad lib it. You know you change the ending or change the —

MR: I heard you say something about seeing Shecky Greene for the first time and you were amazed that he had no structure or beginning or ending and still he was hilarious.

PB: I mean I laughed so hard that I was ill. I had no idea. And it was sort of a revelation to me because I had been working in Chicago with a group, the group The Millionaires, and we were there for about six months at one club, it was a really good gig. And older guys, comics, would come in. They started to come in and word was spreading there's this

comic working at the Cairo Club. And so then the guys say, "You remind us of Shecky Greene" and I never heard his name before because he wasn't a TV comic you know. I said, "Who is that?" And they said, "Oh he's out in Vegas, he's making big money, he's doing real good." I said, "Oh great." And so I went to see Shecky, I heard all about him, he was a legend out here, I mean truly a legend, partly because of his wild antics. Shecky found out he was clinically depressed and when he'd drink he would do things, you know, unspeakable things, strange things. And so I went to see him and he came out, he had no opening. And he just started going from there. And then he'd start a story about his mother's cooking. He grew up in Chicago so all the Chicago guys knew him. He'd start with his mother's cooking and he'd say, "She would go to the butcher shop and she'd handle the chickens, we were so poor" and she'd say, "now let me see that one." She'd handle about five or six chickens, then she'd come home and put her hand in a pot of hot water, that's the chicken soup. And see that's the joke there. But then he would take that and turn it inside out. He'd say, "The first time I went to a restaurant I had chicken soup, it was so strong I almost gagged so I went in the kitchen to argue with the chef and the chef had both his hands in the water. I mean, so instead of, it's like a Virgil Partch cartoon or something. It's so off the wall.

MR: It's so interesting because I never heard that before, but I could feel it coming which made it even funnier.

PB: And then he would do this wonderful thing on opera, on "Madame Butterfly" he would do this whole thing about Puccini's genius and how he would do this and how he explains about the ensign on the American ship who is in Japan and he fell in love with this Japanese girl, Madame Butterfly, and she fell in love with him and they lived together and she became pregnant and then they got orders that they had to ship out, and the ensign had this terrible, he was torn because he knew what would happen, you know a half breed baby in Japan was shunned, he knew what he was leaving and it was a terrible thing. And Shecky builds this thing as the music builds behind him, he says Madame Butterfly is standing on top of the cliff and she's watching the ship sail out and she sings the most perfect aria ever written. He says, [sings] "Oh you son 'o bitch." And then he'd be halfway through that and he'd go back to the part with his mother and the chicken, and he would have four or five things going all at once, and then he would finish them all, bada-bing — I mean it was something that you couldn't do on a computer today with all the memory there is.

MR: It seems like eventually bands, established bands personalities start maybe to conflict and I'm wondering if in The Millionaires any of the other members started to resent the fact that you became in the spotlight?

PB: Well no there really wasn't. You know after the first group broke up the guitar player got drafted. The sax player and the drummer were both in the service and out. And I was in the Army Reserves so I was exempt but the guitar player, when he got drafted, and when you have a group like that where you're singing — we used to sing vocals like the Four Freshmen and nothing's written on paper you know, we just learned everything and we had these comedy routines. Because I found out when we started with the group when we'd go to clubs they'd say, "Do you play rock & roll?" And we said, "No, that's like blasphemy to us."

MR: Why?

PB: Well because it was so simple. You know first of all the time is flat-footed, there's no life to the time, and secondly you know it's four or five chords. They don't deal with augmented ninths and flatted fifths or anything like that, which jazz does. So it's a different part of music.

MR: Well what was your — name a few tunes that were in The Millionaires' repertoire.

PB: Well we did all standards, Cole Porter, Rodgers & Hart, we did, you know, Jerome Kern. We did all those kind of tunes. And then you know the jazz tunes.

MR: Were people dancing to your music?

PB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah, okay.

PB: And they were all very good players. Anyway when this group broke up we added another guitar player from the hometown but he was a pain in the neck and he was sort of a prima donna and that didn't last long. So then we added two more guys and it just never felt right. So finally the group broke up and I had a chance to reorganize it so I got a trombone player from Scranton, Tony Ardito, he was a great player, and a guitar player from Coatesville, Pennsylvania that we had never heard before but he had a good name, and a drummer from Baltimore named Joey Preston. His real name was Joey Prestiani. But Joey was a child prodigy. When he was 14 he was playing with the Kenton band. I mean he was a brilliant, brilliant player. He did a lot of movies and he wore short pants when he was like 10 or 11 because he was small and got away with it. And this group came out here and we were killing them out here in Vegas. And then the guitar player, who was a lot older than us, he decided he didn't want to travel anymore. So he stayed with one of the show bands and then we just worked as a trio without him and we added a local piano player and we were at the Thunderbird Hotel for a long time, we were sort of like the house group in the lounge there. And one of the owners of the Thunderbird was very fond of us. He was a guy who owned a club in Wichita many years ago and he bought into the Thunderbird but couldn't be on the license because he had a felony conviction. But at his club in Wichita Charlie Parker used to work there and he was

always getting in trouble because he'd go in the boiler room and smoke a joint and it would get into the ventilator. People would smell this weird smell. So Lee Dear was the man's name I can tell you, he's since passed away, he was a dear man. And he said to Charlie Parker, "You've got to get out of here, go to New York." He later saved the life of maybe the best guitar player who ever lived, Joe Pass, who was a terrible user of hard drugs. And he took Joe Pass physically by the hand, took him out to the airport in Vegas, put him on a plane to Los Angeles to get in touch with Synanon, and told the flight attendant, "He's not to leave the plane until Synanon comes on the plane." This was the old days before security, and gets him and takes him. And anyway Joe Pass went into Synanon and straightened his life out and disappeared for a couple of years and then I had the good fortune to be traveling with Nat King Cole at the time and Nat said, "You've got to hear this guitar player." And he put this record on, I says, "Wow, who is that?" He said, "Some guy named Joe Pass." I said, "Joe Pass!"

MR: Nice.

PB: Yeah. Anyway this guy Lee Dear said, "Look, why don't you put together the group that you want and I'll sign the contract, you can stay here." So I got Mike Wofford on piano, who is an internationally known jazz player, a bass player from Lake Tahoe named Chuck DeLora who is a great player, Richie Matteson, who is like a great, great jazz educator. He was at North Texas State and then he went to North Florida and won every award there and we got a girl singer who was married to Maynard Ferguson years ago, a girl named Kay Brown. So we had three horns, three rhythm, and a girl singer. And Richie and I put our heads together and wrote — Richie especially was way above me man, he wrote unbelievable stuff. And we were together like three months and Capitol Records signed us to a recording deal the group was really strong. And then one night we were working at Lake Tahoe and our manager showed up and said, "I'm sorry about the problems." "What problems?" He said, "Well this guy said this, and this guy." And like overnight the group — everybody left. And I had signed for all the uniforms and the singer's gowns and everything. So everybody took off and I was living in a rented house in Vegas with three kids and my wife was pregnant with the fourth. Had no income. So it was a real bad time. And then I went to see Frank Ross from the Mary Kay trio. They were like big stars in Vegas. I went to see Frank Ross and Frank said, "You've got to go on your own. You shouldn't be with a group." And he says, "I'm going to call an agent, he's going to call you." So this agent calls me and said, "I have a gig for you in Spokane, Washington." I never heard of Spokane. I'd heard of Seattle but I'd never heard of Spokane. He said, "It's some kind of steak house or something called The Stockyards Inn in Spokane and it doesn't pay much but —" I said, "Okay but" I said, George Burke was the agent's name — forgive me for remembering these names, this is like sixty years ago

and for some reason it popped into my head. But George Burke set it up and it was my first single ever and so I was terrified. And I said, "George I'm ashamed to tell you I don't have the money to get to Spokane and I don't have a car." So he said, "Well take the bus." I said, "Okay but it takes like a day and a half to get there on the bus." It stopped everywhere, you know, Fresno and Elko, and so George Burke said, "Okay I'll send you a money order." This was before you could transfer money. And so I said, "Okay but I need it by" whatever — like Thursday if I'm going to get to Spokane for Saturday. He says, "Don't worry about it." Anyway it didn't get there and I called him and said, "Look, I never got the money and the bus is leaving in five minutes and I can't get on it." And George just washed his hands of everything — this is to another agent in Spokane, a guy named John Powell. He lives up there, and I don't know, just call him. So I called John Powell and John said you know, "They're advertising you and everything, direct from Las Vegas." So I said — so he said, "I'll send you an airline ticket." You could wire it in those days. So he sent me an airline ticket and the pay was $300 a week and the airline ticket was $309. So before I got on the plane I was out $9. Anyway I got the ticket, I flew to Spokane, and I had on one of the suits from the band and a very hip topcoat and a goatee. And John Powell looked at me and I looked like an alien. I mean Spokane is really conservative, right wing. And he looked at me and he said, "This isn't a jazz gig you know." I said, "Well I know, John, I'll do the best I can." So we drove out, it was February and it was pouring rain. And we drove out — my youngest son was just born a few weeks before this. So we drove out to the club and there was a big sign on the club. It said, "Direct from Las Vegas" and he misspelled Las Vegas, he had L-O-S. And then I realized why it's called The Stockyards Inn, it was in the middle of the stockyards, so we had to walk on planks across the steer poop to get to the club. And the guy's name who owned it was — his dad was very rich and this guy wanted to have a club so his dad said here, here's some money. His name was Rocky Rothrock. And I went in and the room was okay, it was a rectangular room, a decent size, and he said, "Well what do you need?" I said, "Well the best thing would be a piano bar." Well you mention a piano bar to most people today they sort of know what you're talking about. But Rocky, you know, from another planet somehow. He said, "What's that?" I said, "Well it's like you've got a bar, the piano, it's like a bar and the people can sit and talk to you and drink while you're playing requests." And he said, "Oh that's a good idea. I got you covered." So I went into work that night and he had an old upright piano up against the wall and he built a bar around the back of me. So the people were looking at the back of my head and the piano was almost unplayable and so I did the best I could. And then after a couple of nights more and more people started to come into the bar and I said, "Rocky you know it'd help if there was a light in the corner of that room you know." He said, "Okay." So I went in

the next night and I'm not exaggerating, he had a cord hanging down from the ceiling and a 100 watt bulb with like a poolroom shade over it." And I'd go [scats] and turn on the light and everybody'd go whoa [shields eyes] you know it was dark in the room. And then I said, Rocky, with this piano like this I can't see the people." So the next invention of his was on top of the piano he mounted a mirror from a dresser and it would swivel. And he gave me a dowel so I could reach up and move the mirror. My final request was if I could get a microphone. He said, "Well we've got a sound system in the whole building," he said, "that's no big deal, I'll get you a microphone." So he got me one of those little microphones like Broderick Crawford in "Highway Patrol" you know, Broderick Crawford, where you'd squeeze the thing and talk into it. And I'd set it on the edge of the piano just where the keyboard ends, I'd set it there. And then I'd pick it up and I'd turn to the audience and I was doing jokes and I was doing local stuff and people started to come in, the place was getting crowded and everything. And then the crowning blow was I was right in the middle of a story one night and over the same speakers that my voice is emanating I hear, "Johnson party of six, two chicken fried steaks, two fried chicken." It was like it was hooked up to the cook and everything. So I started yelling at this guy who was the manager. His name was Mr. McClusky. And even his son called him Mr. McClusky, he was that revered as a restaurant manager in Spokane. So I deleted the "Mr." it was blasphemy. I called him "McClusky" and then boy people were going oh my God he called him McClusky, it was like a big sin. Anyway I carried on.

MR: You've come a long way, baby.

PB: Oh yeah. I mean I literally used to go in the men's room in between shows, I'd be in tears you know thinking I just left this killer group, you know I had these big arrangements and here I am working this dumb —

MR: What was the phone calls to home like?

PB: Well it was tough. I'd talk to the kids, the other three kids were old enough to talk to me and my old lady and my youngest son was just a baby at the time. It was very difficult. And then this manager, this John Powell, you know at least now I was making $300 a week, I could send, you know $250 home through Western Union so she could pay the rent and buy some food. And it was really just stretching it out. And then John Powell said, "Hey, you're packing the room, I'm going to ask for more money." And then he came to me and said, "Rocky said he can't afford to pay any more money so I got a club across town you can work called The Plantation and the guy likes you, he's been in to see you. Perry Williams is his name." I said great. So I went to the club, he says, over there you're going to have a band behind you. I said, "Whoa, I'm back in show biz." So I went there and the band consisted of an organ player named Tony Pasco. No matter what he played it sounded like a roller rink, you know that sound. So we rehearsed a little bit with

Tony and the rest of the band was a drummer. So it was an organ and drums, and the drummer was the owner of the club, Perry Williams, who played drums once in a while. So opening night, as bad as it was, it was still better than where I was and so I was thanking God for that and I went out and I was singing some song to open, "The Lady is a Tramp" or something, to open the show. And halfway through the drums stopped. Well you know I'm in show business, I'm not going to turn around and say what happened to the drummer — so I just keep singing. Out of the corner of my eye I see my drummer, who is the club owner, walking down the aisle in front, picks up to menus "party of two" he seated people. My drummer was seating people during the show. It was like — anyway —

MR: You know somehow that seems like if I can get through this man, I can do pretty much anything.

PB: That's exactly what it was.

MR: Yeah. And my other question was when I've watched some of your shows on video, like most comedians the timing and the space, the silence followed by the punch line is so much a part of the success. And was that something you learned over the years?

PB: Yeah. And that's the application of the music too that's so important to the tempo and rhythm and people will laugh at something that isn't even funny if the tempo and the rhythm is right you know.

MR: I had an interesting coincidence that I saw a Marx Brothers movie between the time that we had first spoken and I wonder if they were an influence on you?

PB: Yeah I loved the Marx Brothers and the Ritz Brothers. I had the good fortune to meet Harry Ritz before he passed away. He had lived here in Vegas and was in a rest home of sorts. And Joe Delaney who is a newspaper guy, the only real decent critic we've ever had here, Joe called me and said, "Harry Ritz is in a home, do you want to go by?" And so went by and spent a couple of afternoons with him and he still was sharp. You know he would forget things but he still was funny.

MR: Well a mutual friend told me to ask you about Chico Marx.

PB: Yeah he was special. He was special. And they were all, I mean Harpo, Chico, they were all incredibly talented. They weren't just funny, they got it somehow. And I think the criteria for any art form is its longevity. I mean you don't see people look at the Mona Lisa and say aah, shoulda had more blue, or looking at the Sistine Chapel and say no you should have used more reds. I mean 500 years later you look at that painting and it still takes your breath away. So the real criteria for artists is longevity. And the Marx Brothers are still funny today when you watch them. Abbott and Costello are still funny today. The routines they developed in Burlesque and in Vaudeville, you know, their movies were just an extension of Who's on First. You know, the two characters created by them in that

one routine. And it took years to create that routine. Unfortunately today that part of the puzzle it no longer exists. Where there used to be theaters where you could work a week at Wilkes Barre, then a week in Philadelphia, a week in Pittsburgh, a week in Allentown, a week in Altoona, then you'd hit Ohio. And then after that there were supper clubs. And that was my background, working supper clubs.

MR: So you must have had a lot of, if you were on the road doing your solo act you had a lot of time to think about what am I going to do tonight. Did you find a way to rehearse your acts like in front of a mirror?

PB: No I never did that. And I never planned anything either. I would go out and check the audience out, you know the first couple of minutes you learn to do that. You get some kind of vibe from them and you see where you can go, how far you can go in this direction, being off the wall, or how conventional you have to be in this direction. So you can analyze them quickly like that, parse them and get some idea of where they're at and then you can work from that frame of mind. But I never, even the band, I never tell the band, I just tell them we're going to open with that one tune you know. I would do a song to open the show and then put a comedy thing in the middle of it. And I tell them, "We'll open with this." And that was all I ever told them. And I always worked with bebop guys because they understood where I was going without me — I never had to turn around and say I'm going to do "Oklahoma" but I'm going to add extra beats or nothing. I would just say here's the score from "Oklahoma" and I'd say "Oklahoma" and I'd put extra beats in. And the drummer would just follow along and the piano player would know. So you know with the beboppers, duck soup. That's why I always used the real hip guys. I didn't have to rehearse them much at all.

MR: Yeah. Improvising was not a foreign word to them.

PB: Yeah. So they knew, and they understood too, you know if I was doing something — if I would say a certain thing they knew that they should boo me or they should say "yeah" or they should say "right on" and be real hip or something. You know they understood. They got that. That's why I always loved the Tonight Show so much because they're all bebop guys in that band and they understood — I never had to say to them — you know sometimes I'd go out and I'd be talking to the audience telling a story you know. I'd say, "This guy was a terrible man and he actually killed this woman, strangled her in a parking lot" and then I'd say to the audience, "excuse me" and I'd go over to the band and I'd say, "You know it's not like you guys have so much to do, I'm out there by myself and you're just sitting here. So if I say the lady got killed, would it hurt you guys to go like 'oooo'" and then for the rest of the routine you have all this — and then the audience is doing it too. And it makes it so stupid but I mean it's really funny.

MR: Did you ever think about a routine, for instance your fourth trumpet player, and determine in your head, make a decision, this is not too inside?

PB: Well you know what happened? I analyzed that for a long time because first of all I used to play with those bands. So I —

MR: You knew what it was like.

PB: Yeah. There's a sense of reality and you can't fool musicians when you do that. They know that when you're doing that routine, "Oh he knows, he was there." They get the little inside things you know. But I think people get that because when you graduate from high school the class always has to sing a song there on graduation day. The whole class is there and some vocal teacher, head of the drama department, whomever that is, they conduct this song and it's usually a patriotic song or something, or "You'll Never Walk Alone" or one of those things you know. And there's a solo part and the chick who gets the solo part is a chick that nobody ever likes, she's a real prima donna. You know. And so the rest of us end up singing, [sings] As you walk through the storm/And the sun is high/ooh aah, and the rest of us get to do that. And so we always carry that through the rest of our life, that we were in the background and this chick that we hated got to sing the lead. So I think the people sort of get that.

MR: Yeah. They've all experienced it in some fashion. Yeah. As time went by did you find that filling a half an hour or whatever got easier? I shouldn't talk about myself but I want to tell you that I was in a rock band for a while and somehow I ended up doing a 10-minute opening comedy routine. And I called myself Billy Schechter. And I found it was the hardest thing I've ever done.

PB: Yeah that's tough.

MR: Only ten minutes, and I would put cue cards on the floor to look down if I couldn't think of what to talk about.

PB: Well I'm going to tell you a perfect analogy of that. For some reason I've done a couple of shows with George Plimpton, the author. And you know George Plimpton, before he writes he does it. He played football with the Chicago Bears and he got busted up bad. Then he did a trapeze thing and threw his back out, but he does everything before he writes it. And George came to Vegas to do a comedy routine at Ceasar's Palace, and he worked with Milton Berle and Alan King and Cosby. They said to him, "Do this: Light a cigarette when you do this, put your hand in your pocket," they told him what to do. And one night at Ceasar's Palace, I forget who was headlining, but they announced a special treat today we have a new comic, and they didn't use his right name. And so George Plimpton went out on stage and he did like eight minutes. And George Plimpton, we were talking about it on Merv's show. And George Plimpton said, "Merv," he says, "of all the things I've ever done, you know and I threw my back out and how incredibly painful that

is and when I broke my collar bone" he said, "none of those things came close to the pain that I suffered those eight minutes on stage with the entire audience looking at me and they hated me." He said, "It's a — it really is the worst death I've ever suffered in my life."

MR: Did you ever suffer the death like that?

PB: Yeah sometimes it happens. You know Al Jolson was nuts when he said no such thing as a bad audience. You get audiences — somebody did a test many, many years ago, maybe 75 years ago or something, in New York City where they had every entity that had entertainment call in to a certain phone bank and rate the audiences after each show. And they kept records. And the funny part was except for a real rare exception the funny part was when the show at the Copacabana, the audience was bad, the audience was bad at the Latin Quarter. There's some atmospheric, who knows, vibes, news, something in the news that day that changes your perspective. But yeah, you get a bad audience. But it's happened to all of us. Even Shecky talks about it, you know, and he was the King of the Kings. He said, "I really bombed here, bombed there, you know, so you learn. And sometimes you're in a bad situation — you know they booked me at the Steel Pier in Atlantic City opening for Smokey Robinson and the Miracles. Well you know that audience, they were all kids who wanted to see Smokey Robinson. They were yelling and screaming. And you can't do my act.

MR: "What's a fourth trumpet?"

PB: Yeah. So what does that mean. So it's just a bad booking.

MR: Yeah. When you were — knew that you were recording for an LP did you change anything in your routine because the physical visual part of it wasn't going to be there?

PB: Yeah. No I just did it. You know my theory was always different, in fact I had a long talk with Johnny Carson rest his soul, one night I was talking to him and he said, he says, "You get it, you do the right thing." I said, "What do you mean?" He said, he says, "You do what I've always done" he says, "I don't do anything I do for the television audience. I do it for the audience there, the 500 people." And that's what I always did. I worked to the 500 people there and let the director, let him translate that to the picture on the tube. That's not my job, that's his you know. But I just worked for whoever was in the room besides me. And that's what I did with the albums, and then they'd do some editing but they never required much 'cause I never did any blue material.

MR: Did you fall afoul of Johnny Carson for a number of years?

PB: Yeah. I did the show in New York, the Tonight Show when it was in New York. That was a long time ago.

MR: And Skitch Henderson was on that.

PB: Skitch Henderson's band, yeah. And Mel Torme I'm almost certain it was Mel, was on the show and Carson is a big jazz lover and so Mel Torme was a God to him you know. And Mel Torme was on before me, and then they told me, "This is your first shot so you don't go to the panel, do your stand-up and walk out." So I did something very hip. Maybe it was the fourth trumpet, I don't know what I did but Carson actually came and got me physically and took me to the panel. And everybody's going, "Whoa man, you are made, he's never done that before." And we spent a whole segment there and then he said, "Stick around," and we came back to the next segment and he was telling me short stories and I was telling him some. And Mel Torme, and Mel Torme started to laugh while Carson was telling a story. And Mel didn't mean anything personally by it but he said, "I'm so sorry John, I didn't mean to stop your story but I can't stop laughing at that thing Pete did. And Carson turned like right now it was like how dare you try to be hipper than me. And he ended the segment there and it was 14 years I was not allowed on the Tonight Show. And Peter Lassally, who is the producer, is my biggest fan in the entire world. And yet he would call every once in a while and say, "I'm so sorry I mentioned your name to Johnny and he threw a book on the floor" you know whatever it is. And then Carson started to take time off and they were having guest hosts and John Davidson was the first one. I had worked with John before, we were good buddies. And John asked me on and so I talked to Peter, I said, "Is it okay? I don't want to get you in trouble here 'cause you're my friend." He said, "No, as long as Carson's not here." So I started to do it with all the guest hosts and then one day they called me, and I'd done it like fifty times or something, and one day they called me and said, "Can you do it Friday." And I said, "Yeah, that's fine." And I asked who's on because if you have a lot of singers I'll do straight stand-up. If you have a lot of talkers I'll do something more musical 'cause if the show is good then I'm good. You know you want the show to be good. The show is the thing. That's the motto. And so he told me who's on, and I said, "Who's hosting?" He said, "Johnny." I said, "Oh no. I'm on the list, I don't do it with Johnny." And the guy said, "Ooh sorry, I didn't know. I'll call you next week." I said okay. Then he called right back and he said, "I just mentioned your name to Carson and he said great." So I went there, I didn't apologize, he didn't apologize, and we started this symbiotic relationship where I would barge into his private make-up room when he was getting make-up and tell him the latest dirty joke, or he'd tell me the latest joke, and we had this thing, and I was one of the very few acts to work that show when they'd say, "What are you going to do" the associate producer would say, "What are you going to do?" And I always tell them, "I'm going to do the poodle joke, I'm going to do the rabbit joke." And they'd say, "You always say that and you never do that joke." And I say, "Well I'm going to do it this time." And they would never ask me to do the joke. Every other comic you had to do

the routine in an office to somebody so they could make sure, the continuity, they could make sure they didn't have to censor something.

MR: Is there a rabbit joke?

PB: I don't know. I'm just making it up. And then they'd say, "How much time you going to do?" And I always said, "Six minutes." And they'd say, "You never do six minutes, you always go over." I'd say, "Well this time I'm going to —" they never complained. And once in a while when they'd say to me, "Look we're short of time that last segment ran really long with so-and-so actor or some politician or something. So we don't have much time, do you want to just tell one joke or do you want to just go to the panel?" I said, "Look let me just tell one joke," and I would start this joke and I would start explaining the carpeting that was on the floor of the club, it was a high-low carpeting. And then I would ask people, like say, "Doc, you remember that guy" and everybody would get hip to what was going on and they would start doing this real long answer. I'd say it to Ed McMahon. Incidentally Ed and I were — it was a strange relationship. Ed McMahon hated me more than any person in the world. Hated me. I think it was because Carson didn't like me. He was sort of like plugged into Carson. But Ed told Joe Delaney, the newspaper guy here in town, Ed was sitting at the pool and Joe came by and they were good friends and Ed went on for thirty minutes about how he hates me and he couldn't believe that Joe Delaney was writing good things about me. And then so instead of accosting Ed I started to really bug him — I'd do routines and in the middle I'd say, "You know like the one plane that Ed used to fly. Ed, you're a pilot aren't you?" I would bring him in and he would begrudgingly start by saying yeah. And then he had his secretary and her fiancé, they were coming to Vegas to get married and Ed had a plane chartered because he was working at the Frontier Hotel. He got them a hotel room which was comped and he got them dinner in there which was comped, big deal. And then he brought on the plane a Laughing Cow cheese and a bottle of some real cheap wine. You know, not Thunderbird but something really cheap. And the pilot was a friend of mine, George Hernandez. He had a commercial license but he was a piano player and entertainer. And George came to me and said, "Hey," he says, "did you drive down?" I said, "No, I flew down." He says, "Why don't you fly back, Ed's got a plane chartered, a twin engine, you know, the Queen Anne, the Queen. It's a beautiful plane." He says, "Come on back with us." I said, "Hey Ed I don't get along with." He says, "Just sit in the back, Ed won't know you're there." So anyway I did, I went out and I sat way in the back and Ed got on the plane with his secretary and he said, "Well you're going to enjoy your trip to Vegas, I got you seats at this and — " which didn't cost Ed anything you know. He's going on and on. And halfway there George Hernandez leaned out, there's no door to the cockpit, and he says, "Hey Pete, do you remember that thing?" And I said, "Yeah."

And they didn't know I was sitting back there. So they all turned around and they saw me and they say, "Hey, we didn't know you were back there." I said, "Well that's okay, congratulations on your wedding and I wish you health and good luck." They said, "Thank you." And then the chick said, "Wait a minute, you're that guy plays the piano with his nose." I said, "Yeah, I'm afraid so." The two of them left Ed and came back and talked to me. And he was just, I mean burning man. So that didn't help at all. Because I kept doing this thing, you know the Biblical "heap coals of kindness upon your enemy." I kept doing that. And then finally, like Ed started to take me in the audience to introduce me to friends of his. Really weird. And Carson and I got like really close. And see when he comes in to do the show he's flanked — you know Ed McMahon's already there doing the warm-up, but he's flanked by Peter Lasally, Ed deCordova, and a security guard. Or Fred deCordova. He said, "So no one's to approach —" anyway Carson would leave them and come over to me and telling me the latest joke or something, and we'd always have this inside thing. I mean I don't know what the deal was but —

MR: You were a magnet.

PB: Yeah. There was something that he found interesting, and we became really, really close.

MR: Of course he had prompters, either teleprompters or you know the things on the big cards or whatever.

PB: Yeah. Cue cards they used for a while.

MR: Did you ever use cue cards?

PB: No.

MR: I'm not surprised.

PB: No. Well now on the — the first shows I did the Steve Allen show, if they asked me to do the sketches they didn't have teleprompters yet, they had cue cards. And what they would do is in rehearsal Steve Allen would forbid the use of the punch lines at rehearsals. So he'd do the joke: "Hey Fred, what time do you leave for the bank?" "I'm leaving for the bank but I have to go somewhere first." "Where do you have to go?" "Rabadaza." You weren't allowed to read the punch lines. So when you did it that night on camera it was fresh for the first time and you're hearing it. It's a dangerous thing but —

MR: He was quite — you described him as very analytical and —

PB: Well he was, about everything.

MR: Yeah.

PB: Steve had to know the reason why everything worked. He told me once he burned his hand, or his finger or something, and somebody was driving him down to the clinic and he held his finger out the window and the rushing air soothed the pain and he started this whole thing where he wanted to find out why rushing air — it was like that one — I did a show in Vancouver called "The Next Line." The producer is a good friend of mine and it

was a good premise. It was a game show. It was fun. And he wanted to do some music in it. So he said, "Can we find enough" — we were doing 65 shows — he said, "Can we find 65 songs?" And the premise was they'd show an old movie and then they'd freeze frame and the celebrities would come up with the next line. One of them had the right one and the other ones had wrong ones, and the contestants would have to guess who had the right. So with the music somebody'd sing and he says, "Can we find enough songs that are public domain so I don't have to pay ASCAP for all these songs?" So I said I don't know. So I started, and I said, "Wait a minute. You know I've written a few songs. Let me see how many songs I can write." So I started writing words and music you know. And I sort of sequestered myself, and I actually wrote 65 songs and we did them on the show. And it was very successful. And I thought I'm going to write to the Guinness people because I don't know if anybody's ever written 65 songs in like a 6-week period. And then I read somewhere Steve Allen wrote like 25,000 songs or something. And I said, "That's it. I give up man. He was incredibly prolific.

MR: Yeah. I remember him saying something like he sat in front of a picture window and did that as people were watching or some such thing.

PB: Yeah he did one called "Ocupado." On airplanes if you were getting up to go to the restroom or something they had a little plastic card that said "occupied" you'd put it on your seat. On the reverse side it was in Spanish for non-English-speaking people. It said "Ocupado." And he found that word — so he wrote a Latin tune, a samba — not a samba but a rhumba called "Ocupado." I mean if you look over there he would write something.

MR: Did you ever want to play like a music-only gig and find that your reputation as a comedian got in the way of that?

PB: Yeah. Yeah that happened. I used to — I was getting my kicks, I'd go out to the union building when the musician's union here was so strong, they had the building off Tropicana. And I'd go out there and play with the rehearsal bands, you know the kicks bands. And you'd go out and you could just play and play and play and it would go on for hours. So that was okay. But if I tried to do it in public somebody'd come up and say, "You're going to play with your nose, aren't you?" or something like that.

MR: Yeah. A few years ago I saw a pretty well known comedian and I don't think he'd been on stage for five minutes when he'd use most of the profanity that George Carlin had written about. And I wonder how you feel about that?

PB: Yeah it bothers me. In fact it bothered Shecky Greene. Shecky said to me one night, he says, "I've walked out on several comics that were too dirty for me." You know? And we all — you know — knew all those words and you know when we were in totally male company or we were with other entertainers we'd tell jokes that are really obscene. But not in public. That's a different thing. I couldn't do that.

MR: You are familiar with the Bill Crow *Jazz Anecdotes* book?

PB: No I'm not.

MR: Okay well he gathered all kinds of wonderful stories from jazz musicians and I wanted to — I'm checking his veracity that he wrote that you were doing a show one time and you were going to do "Tenderly" on the broom and no one could find a broom? And finally someone came up with a vacuum cleaner?

PB: Yeah. I called it a Fender Broom.

MR: Yeah. I don't play no Fender Broom.

PB: Yeah.

MR: Okay well good, he was truthful then.

PB: Yeah. Yeah that happened at Lake Tahoe. I was working there, a great group behind me too, all beboppers in the showroom at Harvey's Hotel. Yeah. Will Osborne the old band leader was the entertainment director, he was a great guy. And it was Christmas time and what happened was one night it started to snow, we get up the next morning and the snow was over the cars at Lake Tahoe. Five feet is not bizarre. And so all the roads were closed because Tahoe's at the top of this real winding — no easy way up there. And so everything was closed. There were no tourists in yet for the holidays and so I walked out on stage for the first show and there were like twelve people in the room. Then there were dealers you know, 21 dealers, craps dealers. They just came in because nobody was in the casino. And so it was funny and Will Osborne you know was joking, "They finally found out what kind of an act you have, this is the best crowd." We joked around and for the second show, you know, he said, "If you want to go home —" I said, "Na we're here we'll do a second show." And so the curtain opened and the room was packed with all the employees and they were all reading a newspaper.

MR: Was that a set-up?

PB: Yeah. And I mean we laughed. And so I wasn't going to do my regular show so I played a song on the piano, did a song on the trumpet, did a song on the accordion, I used to play Fender bass too. I did a song on the bass. And then I said, "Well that's about it." And Will Osborne threw a broom out and he said, "Here play this." And I picked it up, I swear it was like I'd been doing it for a year. I said, "Okay I'd like to play a ballad, 'Tenderly.'" And they backed me up, and they understood when I doubled the time the band knew. It was like I'd been doing it for years. I had the mutes from the trumpet so I put a mute in the broom and played it real soft. I used a plunger.

MR: That whole thing was spontaneous?

PB: Yeah it just happened one night. Incidentally I have a big plaque from the American Academy of Recording Sciences for being the world's best broomist. That's incidentally, a Grammy.

MR: Did you write — when you had a band accompaniment did you write those charts or did you hire —

PB: Yeah. Well I've written some stuff for college bands too. I probably would have difficulty writing it today but at the time I was doing it a lot and I had help from people. Certain people would say, you know, "If you're going to voice this do this this way" or something. Good people.

MR: Nice.

PB: When I was in high school for my junior year — my sophomore year I went right in with the advanced band. And for my junior year I was first chair All-State Pennsylvania for the conference they have where you go to Harrisburg or someplace and you know work with a big time director. And same thing in my senior year. But for my senior year I wrote the thing for our band to play, the drum solo. It was not a set of drums just snare drum, and different tricks. But I wrote it for the band and it was okay.

MR: And you had score paper and you were doing it —

PB: Well I never really worked from a score. I'd start with an idea and write like the trumpets first and then the trombones and then the saxes and then sometimes I'd have to go back and say wait a minute this has to be like this.

MR: Oh wow.

PB: But I'm not in the same class as Don Costa or those guys who would just be on an airplane and take a paper and write a chart for Sinatra that would be swinging like crazy without any score.

MR: I can see the stewardess with you, "Would you like some coffee?" "Don't interrupt me, I'm writing —"

PB: Yeah frequently I would carry manuscript and write a chart on the plane on the way to the gig, something I thought of that I wanted to do in the show.

MR: Did you have any trumpet heroes growing up?

PB: Well I think the same ones everybody did: Harry James, Louis Armstrong of course, Harry James. Incidentally I did a show with Louis Armstrong called "Hollywood Palace" in Hollywood obviously, and hung out with Louis Armstrong for three days and he was the most amazing human being. He told me stories too, I mean boy, he was the best. And then Harry James took it to the next level. Harry lived here in Vegas so I got to see him frequently at different benefits and things. But then I got close to Buddy Childers who played lead on the Kenton band, and I worked with Maynard, did a bunch of concerts with him, and Doc of course who is in a league by himself.

MR: What about Rafael Mendez?

PB: Yeah. I have to tell you, in fact one of the great stories of my life, I'm working a club in Seattle. This was right after Spokane. It was the year of the World's Fair in 1962. I have a

great trio behind me and I'm working this little club called Rosellini's 410. It was a very hip place, and it was packed every night. I'm working it and somebody sends up a note that says, "Rafael Mendez is in the audience." And I said well it's somebody named Rafael Mendez but obviously it's not THE Rafael Mendez, he's the greatest classical trumpet player that ever lived. And from the back of the room I hear, "Yeah he's here." I said, "What's he doing here?" "He's conducting the orchestra out at the fairgrounds for the big show, the Roy Rogers show." It was a big orchestra and Rafael Mendez was doing a song and, you know. I said my God Rafael Mendez is in the audience, "Ladies and gentlemen, the greatest trumpetist who's ever lived." And some drunk yelled, "Have him sit in." And with that I chastised this drunk, said, "Sir you don't understand. Rafael Mendez is above what we're all doing or thinking here. He is on a level —" And Rafael Mendez said, "Yeah I don't mind." He gets up, he takes my old beat-up trumpet, he turns to the trio and says, "'Tico Tico' in A minor." He does double, triple tonguing and then he does a chorus of the circular breathing where he never breathes and then he goes — and he ends it on a double A above high C, which was like a B on trumpet, almost a double C. Then he hands me the trumpet and gets off the stage, while I stand there looking at the trumpet and the laughs start, and I keep looking at it and I look up at him and the laugh gets bigger and I look at the band and they all go like this and the laugh gets bigger you know. And I look at the trumpet again, examine it you know, and the laughs just kept getting bigger and bigger. It's like what the hell am I going to do with this thing there's nothing left. Every note in the world has been played. And finally I put the trumpet down and I got a round of applause like it was the longest laugh I've ever had in my life. And then I took the kids out, the three because the young one was too little. I took the kids and I had them fly up to Seattle because I was there for a long time, my wife and the kids. And I took them out because Rafael Mendez said, "Come on" he was Roy Rogers' manager, Art Rush was his manager for like 30 years, never had a contract, never had an argument, he was a wonderful, kind man. Art Rush said, "Bring your family out to see Roy Rogers in the show." So I took them out and I met Art Rush there and he gave me a nice hug, and these are my three kids. He said, "I bet the kids would like to ride on Trigger." He brought Trigger out, who was old at the time. And put the kids on Trigger and they rode around a little bit. And I said wow this is really something, I mean if you grew up in our generation Roy Rogers and Trigger, that was you're talking about legends. So then we go up in the stands and in the middle of the show Rafael Mendez says I'd like to do this solo trumpet piece, whatever he was going to do. He says, "I'd like to dedicate it to my buddy Pete Barbutti, another great trumpet player in the stands," and everybody applauded. I said, "Did you hear that?" And the kids said to me, "Yeah, Dad, but we rode Trigger." I thought yeah, everything is relative.

MR: They have their priorities.

PB: Everything is relative.

MR: I'm glad you brought it up because I was going to ask what did your children think of what their dad did?

PB: Well I'm not sure they knew all the time. And it's funny, the older two kids were very shy and retiring. And the younger two were very outgoing so when they'd meet people they'd say, "It's nice to meet you" and everything. And the other ones were shy to meet people. But I took, when my youngest son, Mark, when he was maybe six or something, his entire world became the Empire State Building. The Empire State Building became the symbol of strength, height, sophistication, it became everything. When you say, "That's a nice car." "Yeah but it's not as nice as the Empire State Building." Maybe it was the rhythm of the word — whatever it was. And so I was going back to do some shows. I was going to do the Arthur Godfrey Radio Show at CBS in New York, I was going to do Merv Griffin and then Mike Douglas down in Philly. So I took him with me. And we went to the Empire State Building. And he said, "Oh this is like —" and I took him to the Godfrey Show and then we did the Merv Griffin Show. Then we went down to Philly to do Mike Douglas and at rehearsal there's was a group called The Little Angels of Korea, they were Korean children and they sang American songs phonetically. They didn't speak any English but they sang this song. And they played drums and things and they were beautiful to watch and they were really good singers. And so they were singing and then they were speaking in Korean. And a foreign language to a kid who's never heard a foreign language before — he said, "What's that sound they're making?" I said well they're speaking. He said, "That's not speaking." I said, "Yes, they're from Korea, another country, that's the way they talk over there." "So how do they understand that?" "Well 'cause that's the way they talk." You know it's something that we say easily but to a child, I went through this whole thing and I summarized the whole thing by saying, "You see they don't speak English so they don't know what we're saying and we don't speak Korean so we don't know what they're saying, but yet we can still all get along. He says, "Oh." So when the rehearsal was over they walked up the aisle and they passed by us and the one little girl, obviously bilingual. She said, "You're a nice looking boy, what's your name?" He said, "My name is Mark." She said, "Well that's a nice name." He said, "Thank you." She walked by, he turned to me and he said, "I though you said I didn't speak Korean." It took him the rest of his life to put that in perspective. He went and told his teacher at school that he speaks Korean. There was no erasing the lesson.

MR: That's amazing. I've really enjoyed this conversation and I want to congratulate you on like creating your own niche it seems like.

PB: Yeah I think — sometimes, Monk, I think sometimes only musicians or people who grew up in that big band era who were close to that, they're the only ones who know what the hell I'm talking about sometimes. But yeah, I still do things, anti-country music you know, but with a tongue and cheek thing.

MR: Was there a camaraderie that occurred because of the road travails, the life on the road?

PB: Yeah boy it's not easy I'll tell ya. I mean it sounds great to be in a new town every two weeks and to have a new band and everything, but first of all there's the getting there and in the beginning flying was really special. Very few people flew you know. There were prop engines and internal combustion engines, they weren't jets. And then jets came in right about the time when I started to travel. But you'd go to the airport and you know you'd travel here, you'd travel there. But then you get to the town and you've got to get to the hotel and they usually have the entertainers, the club owners say you usually stay at this hotel or that. So you get to the hotel and the same thing since I was living in Vegas where everything is open it's still hard to get to a hotel where everything closed — breakfast was finished at ten. If you ordered eggs past ten o'clock the chef came out of the kitchen with a cleaver. That was a cardinal sin. And out here in Vegas you'd order breakfast at four in the morning or breakfast at two in the afternoon, because you know there's no clock everything is going. Bars are going 24 hours, everything. So then you get finished and when you're finished there was nowhere to go, everything was closed. The only place to get something to eat when you got finished with the gig was maybe the Greyhound bus station if they had a lunch counter. Can you imagine what that was like? And so that's why when I first came out here in 1960 we worked with The Millionaires, we worked a gig in South Bend, Indiana and we had our clothes packed and we did Auld Lang Syne and we went out the back door and broke down, put the stuff in and we left, and January the second I guess it was — we never stopped. We drove straight through. We got to Vegas and I was here for a little while and I called my wife and said, "You've got to get out here, this is — I mean everything is open 24 hours." The only thing that couldn't open was federal things like the banks or the courthouse or something. But every hotel had the cashier so if you needed money and you were working there you'd just go up and say, "Give me a draw slip" and you'd sign it and you'd get a hundred bucks and then you'd pay them back at the end of the week. You know. And they could cash checks for you. You know and the bars are open 24 — not that any of us were drinkers but they were open 24/7. Restaurants are open — you could buy a pair of shoes at four in the morning. And it was like a miracle. The food markets were open 24/7.

MR: Wow you found Shangri-la.

PB: Yeah. And for a person who spent — when we'd get finished when we first started traveling there was no TV and — there was a TV but hotels didn't have them, only just a

few private homes. And so there was the radio. And the only thing on late at night was WWBA Wheeling, West Virginia which was all country you know. So you'd listen to the radio and you'd read a book or read the paper.

MR: Yeah, there's a lot of hours to pass.

PB: Oh man.

MR: Maybe some of your routines came out of that downtime.

PB: I think a lot of them did. Because I've never been able to write. Oddly enough now I could write for TV, for sketches because I did a series in Toronto called Pete's Place. It took place in Vegas but we shot it in Toronto. And the deal was I had a small club off the strip in Vegas and everything went wrong that could go wrong with the club you know. The mob tried to move in and this and that. And so I asked a bunch of my friends to come up and I put people together that had never been together before to see if the sparks would fly, and it really worked beautifully. Like Phyllis Diller and Irwin Corey. Dick Shawn and Pat McCormick, the guy who wrote the Tonight Show. I put all these crazy people together and it worked great. They had fun and you know, they got along great. But yeah, I enjoyed that series. It was fun to do. And the opening was cute too. It showed a Rolls Royce going down the strip in Vegas at night, the marquees — Frank Sinatra, Wayne Newton, Elvis Presley — and then the camera — the Rolls Royce stops at a red light and the camera pans back and it shows the driver up front with his proper dress. And I'm sitting in the back of the Rolls Royce with a big cigar you know in my tuxedo. And then the light turns green and the Rolls pulls away and I'm on a bicycle next to it. And I have my trumpet hanging on the handle bars. So I walked up to this club and it's the same Roman printing that's on Caesar's Palace. It said, "Pete's Place." And I look up and the L falls out and then it just — or it says, "Pete's Palace" and the L falls out it just says Pete's Place.

MR: Nice — some good —

PB: Yeah. I could write those routines for these people because I'd write frameworks, because all these people were great. You know and I'd say I'm not going to tell you what to say, you know I'm going to do this. You know Morey Amsterdam and you know like they know a million jokes. So I'm not going to tell you — here's the framework. We do this and from here you go outside, just remember the ending is when I drop the glass on the floor and you say this and then we go to commercial. And it worked great. We did 50 shows, and they were good.

MR: Do you ever get residuals or anything like that?

PB: You know what? Yeah, sometimes. And I have — in fact I have one in my drawer here that I keep I think it's from — oh I don't know where it is now but I think it's from some

show that had a lot of girls on it, the Golden Girls or something like that? Or no it wasn't that sitcom, this was a show, I forget, anyway —

MR: Gold Diggers?

PB: Gold Diggers, yeah. It was some kind of show like that. And I got a residual for two cents. So I kept the check, I didn't cash the check.

MR: Well good. If retirement is in your future then you're all set.

PB: Yeah, right.

MR: Well thank you so much for your time and you've been generous with it. And I wish you the best in your upcoming gigs and may the New Year's Eve horns be scarce.

PB: Yeah amen. Amen. They'll still be there though. I used to call it Amateur Drunk Night.

MR: Yeah.

PB: People who never really drank more than one glass of wine, now it's obligatory to get as foolish as you can be.

MR: Yeah they didn't know how to be drunks.

PB: Yeah.

MR: Thank you very much. I'm going to pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

PB: Okay, Monk.

MR: All right.